CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

AIR TRAFFIC CONTROLLER IN THE AI ERA

Automation can flag a conflict. It cannot take responsibility for separating aircraft full of people.

★ **TL;DR — Median ~$130,000 with a 1–2 year study and training band through a highly selective federal pipeline. The catch: eligibility, medical screening, academy performance and facility assignment are all hard gates.** ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

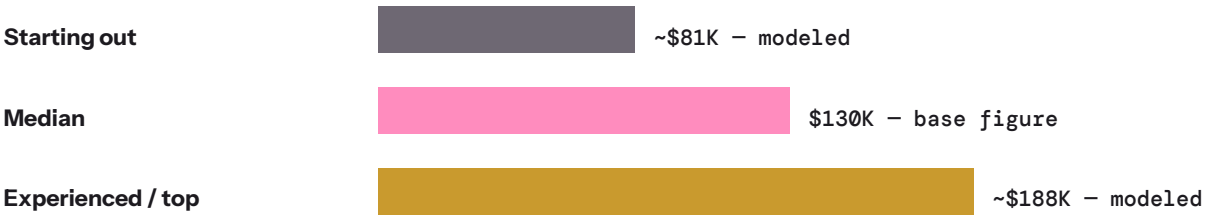
OUR TAKE: YES

MEDIAN ~$130K · TRAINING 1-2 years · AI RISK LOW · STATE LICENSE

- The pay reflects responsibility, scarcity and a demanding selection process.
- AI supports the picture, but clearances and accountability remain human.
- This is not a flexible career you design around your preferred city.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Air Traffic Controller is a ~$130K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A AIR TRAFFIC CONTROLLER ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Monitor aircraft positions, altitude, speed and separation
- ✓ Issue clearances and instructions to pilots by radio

✓ Coordinate arrivals, departures and ground movement with other facilities

✓ Respond to weather changes, equipment problems and emergencies

Think: a live strategist whose moving pieces carry people and cannot pause for a break in concentration.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Traffic-flow tools predict congestion, highlight conflicts and organize flight data before a controller acts.	Controllers still communicate, prioritize, adapt to surprises and carry legal responsibility for the instructions they issue.

⚠ **Most people do not fail because the subject is mysterious. They are stopped by eligibility, testing, medical or security screening, academy standards or the stress of the schedule.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ A mission-critical role with clear standards and strong identity ✓ No two shifts feel exactly the same ✓ A federal career path with structured advancement	✗ Rotating shifts, nights, weekends and holidays ✗ Training and job placement may require relocation ✗ Sustained concentration is the job, not an occasional demand

Good fit? You stay calm under pressure, process several moving problems at once and communicate clearly in few words.
Bad fit? You need location control, a gentle schedule or work that forgives lapses in attention.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — FEDERAL HIRING BID	DOOR B — MILITARY CONTROLLER EXPERIENCE
Apply during an FAA hiring window, pass the required assessments and clear medical and security screening. Successful candidates complete academy training before facility training and certification.	Military air traffic control can provide direct operational experience and a credible route into federal hiring. It is a service commitment, not a shortcut around screening or standards.

Smart move: Prepare for the selection process like an athlete: spatial reasoning, memory, multitasking and clear radio-style communication, while keeping a serious backup career in case a hard gate stops you.

Where you land after: Certified controller, then staff specialist, trainer, supervisor or facility management.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
CHECK THE	TRAIN THE	APPLY IN	CLEAR SCREENING	PASS ACADEMY	CERTIFY AT

STEP 1 — Check the hard gates

FREE · BEFORE YOU APPLY

- Review current FAA eligibility, citizenship, medical, background and hiring requirements.
- Be honest about vision, health, work history and anything that could affect clearance.

STEP 2 — Train the tested skills

FREE–LOW COST · PREPARATION

- Practice spatial reasoning, rapid memory, scanning and prioritization under time pressure.
- Study basic aviation terms, airport operations and radio communication.

STEP 3 — Apply in the hiring window

REQUIRED · WHEN OPEN

- Submit a complete application as soon as an appropriate federal bid opens.
- Complete the official aptitude assessment and every document request on schedule.

STEP 4 — Clear screening

REQUIRED · NO SHORTCUT

- Complete medical, psychological and security processes honestly.
- Stay responsive and organized; missed paperwork can end an otherwise strong application.

STEP 5 — Pass academy training

PAID · FEDERAL TRAINING

- Master procedures, phraseology, radar or tower simulation and separation standards.
- Treat every evaluation as pass-or-go-home preparation, because academy performance matters.

STEP 6 — Certify at your facility

PAID · ON THE JOB

- Complete local training on the airspace, traffic and equipment where you are assigned.
- Earn full certification position by position before working independently.

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

- □ Today: read the current federal requirements and write down every eligibility question you must resolve.
- □ Days 1–30: begin structured practice for attention, memory and spatial tasks, and prepare your application documents.
- □ Days 31–60: keep training, monitor the hiring window and build a realistic backup plan in aviation operations.
- □ Days 61–90: apply immediately if a bid opens; if none opens, continue preparation and keep your documents current.
- □ Day 90: you should be application-ready, actively in the process, or honestly reassessing a hard eligibility gate.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ **CALM VOICE. CLEAR SKIES.** ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.